neighbouring Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. The Sri Lankan civil war fanned Tamil nationalism in Tamil Nadu. Conflicts in Myanmar involving the Chin and Rohingya people threatened to spill over into India.

Stabilizing and integrating India's neighbourhood thus remains a priority. Changes to the international environment, and within many neighbouring states, mean that India has to find new ways to achieve its security objectives and manage domestic political implications. At a minimum, this will require India to do two things. One, it must give diplomatic priority and attention to the region while recasting regional institutions in a more productive light. Two, it must increase the amount and effectiveness of long-term aid, investment, and emergency assistance, and make conscientious efforts to improve connectivity and interdependence. This, in sum, is what India's 'Neighbourhood First' policy is about.

Priority 3. Prioritize Neighbourhood Diplomacy

For periods of time, India neglected developments in the neighbourhood at the highest levels. The mid-1980s to the late 1990s saw a flurry of regional diplomatic activity that was not subsequently matched by Indian leaders, although efforts belatedly picked up. This has helped create the perception that India places a low priority on its neighbourly relations and increases the possible involvement of external actors. One way of demonstrating sustained attention is through regular bilateral visits by senior Indian leaders, including the president, prime minister, and cabinet officials. This should not be unlike the frequent meetings of European leaders or Asian regional exchanges: for example, leaders of the European Union have met eight to ten times per year in recent years. Regular meetings between Indian and other regional leaders on the side lines of diplomatic summits, such as the UN General Assembly, help to show that India still prioritizes its neighbours even at global gatherings. Similarly, incoming visits by regional leaders for consultations should become more routine, while remaining focused on concrete deliverables and outcomes.